Ours was a home filled with books, laughter and arguments. My brother and I were encouraged to have a point of view – and every point of view was acceptable so long as it was expressed courteously and backed with logic and facts. Our mother, a lawyer by training, urged us to excel in our studies. She taught me to read and write in our mother tongue, Sindhi, which laid the foundation of my love of languages. Our father, an idealistic naval officer, told us that we must serve our country, and through personal example, taught us what it meant to truly love one's country.

My first exposure to living abroad was at the age of 17, when I accompanied my parents to the still extant Soviet Union. We lived in a small town in Georgia, on the shores of the Black Sea. I learnt Russian and studied for my Bachelor of Commerce degree via a correspondence course. The Soviet economic system was visibly under pressure. I gained an understanding of the economic perils of a Communist state and what it felt like to live under the whims of an authoritarian regime. The goodness and warmth of the ordinary people we interacted with reminded me of people back home. So did the endless queues; though, in comparison, life in India seemed quite advanced!

I returned to Sydenham College in Mumbai to complete my degree and threw myself into college activities like debating, quizzing and dramatics. I continued my Russian studies and took up French and German in addition. An international students' organization called AIESEC was trying to establish its Indian chapter, and I became one of its founding members.

This was my initial grounding in management. Though full-time students, we set up the organization, raised funding, organized traineeships for Indian students to work abroad, and welcomed foreign students to be trained in India. I myself undertook two traineeships, the first with NKT, Denmark, a telecom cable manufacturer, and the second with Electrolux, Sweden. I learnt how to roll up my sleeves and work on the factory floor and go door-to-door,